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The Impact of Doomscrolling on University Students' Academic Performance and Productivity

Introduction

A quick check of the phone can easily turn into an hour of reading through a succession of distressing headlines, upsetting posts and breaking news. It's a well known phenomenon that you can end up feeling more tense and drained than when you started. That's of course what we refer to as doomscrolling (Sharma et al., 2022) whereby you're constantly searching or scrolling through negative news and other unpleasant content, even if it's doing you harm.

University students are probably the most susceptible to this. They're using their phones for class updates, for communication, for entertainment, for news. They're also under the constant pressure of deadlines and academic work. The feed on social media is infinite so if you open up an app for a fairly mundane reason you can quite easily just end up doomscrolling. This paper looks at the research into doomscrolling and related digital habits (attention, study time, sleep, academic wellbeing etc). The research that's available does show some meaningful associations, it just doesn't prove that doomscrolling in itself leads to lower grades or burnout.

Significance of the Topic

The issue is that students use their digital devices for both study and recreation. In the Bangladesh sample reported by Ahmed et al. (2026) only around 4% of respondents reported using their phone for less than 2 hours a day and 30% reported more than 5 hours. High screen use in itself doesn't necessarily equate to bad behaviour as the students may be using it to study, to coordinate their work, to keep in touch etc. It's just that high levels of use can make it very difficult to realize when a brief break has become a long distraction.

Doomscrolling is a habit worth looking at in its own right rather than just as a synonym for all social media usage. The very nature of doomscrolling is that it's focused on the negative, the distressing, the upsetting content and that can add an additional emotional cost to the time it takes up. Recognizing that distinction is important in enabling students and universities to have a constructive conversation about how we can support attention and wellbeing without necessarily having to treat every instance of phone use as a problem.

Summary and Findings from Sources

Sharma et al (2022) developed a 15-item measure of doomscrolling and found a pattern, linked to hypervigilance and problematic internet use. It was positively correlated with anxiety ($r = .307$) and negatively correlated with self control ($r = -.181$). That helps to characterize the behaviour, though a correlation doesn't tell you which of the two factors came first.

Mali et al. (2026) conducted a survey of 500 students. He worked in the Pune area using a 14-item questionnaire. The students reported a range of tendencies including the habit of opening apps automatically, feeling guilty about the amount of time they spent scrolling and a desire to see content that was tailored to them. The average compulsive scrolling score was higher in the group who used their phones for 4-6 hours (4.13) as opposed to those who used them for 2-4 hours (3.35). The authors found a link between loss of control and screen time ($\beta = .140$) as well as a link with the psychological impact ($\beta = .132$). Their findings point to a potential cycle in which scrolling, fatigue, guilt and reduced productivity could feed into one another.

Ahmed et al. (2026) focused at doomscrolling, sleep quality and academic burnout. He took 390 Bangladeshi undergraduates for his servey. The results were somewhat mixed: there was essentially no relationship between doomscrolling and burnout ($r = -.001$), though poorer sleep was associated with higher levels of burnout ($r = .37$). There was an indirect link reported via sleep, but the survey design precludes any inference of causality. The very fact that the self reports were so unexpected would suggest some caution in how we interpret the relationship between screen use/sleep and burnout.

Two other sources provide some related context. Birotte (2026) looking at ten papers on adolescents found links between doomscrolling and anxiety, cognitive overload and procrastination. Katsiroumpa et al. (2025) found problematic TikTok use to be linked to procrastination. These are studies of different populations and different behaviours so they don't prove the same thing for university students per se, but they do support the discussion of digital habits in general.

Discussion

Overall the sources indicate a valid concern : Compulsive scrolling can be in competition with focused study and may leave students emotionally drained. It's not simply the case that more screen time leads to worse grades . Mobile phones are definitely used for a whole range of academic , social purposes and the studies we've looked at don't really go on to look at grades or compare students over time. The Bangladesh study in specific found virtually no link between doomscrolling and burnout, even though sleep quality was linked to burnout. The difference should be the main focus when making any conclusion.

The research also has some limitations. A lot of it is based on participants self-reporting their own phone use, mood, sleep and their own study behaviour. Those self reports are certainly going to be flawed and the people who choose to participate in an online survey are likely to be different to those who don't. The cross-sectional nature of the research means it only gives you a snapshot at a point in time and so you can't work out whether stress leads to doomscrolling, doomscrolling leads to stress or whether it's some other factor that is driving both.

The Bangladesh context makes this distinction particularly relevant. A student might open up Facebook , Messenger or WhatsApp to check a class notice and then be faced with a completely unrelated piece of news or post. Instead of telling students to stop using their phones completely , it may be more useful to establish some small boundaries around study and sleep. Turn off non-essential alerts during focused work, keep the phone out of reach at night and decide in advance when you're going to stop checking the news. Universities could easily incorporate digital wellbeing into their orientation or counselling provision and it would be fair to acknowledge that students will also need to be online for their courses and for communication.

Conclusion and Recommendations

The research looked at the links and connections between doomscrolling and anxiety, self-control, compulsive behaviour and potential problems with attention and productivity. The evidence on academic burnout is less direct and the survey data don't actually establish a causal link. Students can try out various methods to control their notification settings, news checking , and their study/bedtime routines (e.g. phone free study, phone free bedtime). At the same time universities can provide practical advice on how to manage digital distractions and sleep. Future work should look at students over time and where possible use objective measures of screen time and sleep in addition to academic outcomes.

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